

Top 100 Questions Students Ask About Applying to U.S. Universities

Compiled for Steadfast Student Services — grouped by stage of the journey, in roughly the order students encounter them. Useful as source material for the Resources page, Sofia's knowledge base, and advisor call prep.

1. Choosing a University & Program (12)

1. How do I know which U.S. universities are the right fit for my grades and budget?
2. What's the difference between a community college and a 4-year university?
3. Can I transfer from a community college to a 4-year university later?
4. How many universities should I apply to?
5. What's the difference between public and private universities in the U.S.?
6. Does the ranking of a university actually affect my visa approval chances?
7. Should I choose a school in a big city or a small town?
8. How do I find out if a university is accredited and legitimate?
9. Can I apply to a Master's program without a related Bachelor's degree?
10. What's the difference between a college and a university in the U.S.?
11. How important is it that my intended major has strong job prospects?
12. Should I apply directly to a 4-year school or start with an associate's degree?

2. Admissions Requirements & Documents (13)

13. What documents do I need to apply to a U.S. university?
14. What GPA do I need to get admitted?
15. Do I need to convert my GPA/grading scale to the U.S. 4.0 system?
16. What is a Statement of Purpose (SOP) and how long should it be?
17. How many letters of recommendation do I need, and who should write them?
18. What is a Common App, and do all universities use it?
19. Do I need to submit a resume/CV with my application?
20. What's the difference between conditional and unconditional admission?
21. How long does it take to hear back after I submit my application?
22. What is an I-20, and when will the university send it to me?
23. Can I apply to universities without having graduated yet?
24. Do U.S. universities accept online/attested copies of my transcripts, or do they need to be sealed/official?
25. What happens if my university's name or transcript differs from my passport name?

3. Standardized Tests (TOEFL/IELTS/SAT/GRE/GMAT) (10)

26. Do I need TOEFL or IELTS, and what score do I need?
27. Can I get a waiver for English proficiency tests?
28. Do I need the SAT or ACT for undergraduate admission?
29. Is the GRE or GMAT required for graduate programs?

30. How long are TOEFL/IELTS/GRE scores valid for?
31. Which test is better for me — TOEFL or IELTS?
32. Can I retake a test if I'm not happy with my score, and will universities see all attempts?
33. How far in advance should I book my test date?
34. Do all U.S. universities require the same minimum test scores?
35. Are there universities that don't require standardized tests at all?

4. Costs, Financial Aid & Scholarships (13)

36. How much does it cost to study in the U.S. per year, all-in?
37. What's the difference between tuition and total cost of attendance?
38. Are scholarships available for international students?
39. Can international students get need-based financial aid?
40. What is an assistantship, and how do I qualify for one at the graduate level?
41. Do I have to pay for health insurance separately?
42. What is the SEVIS fee and when do I pay it?
43. How much money do I need to show in my bank account for the visa interview?
44. Can I use a bank loan to cover my proof-of-funds requirement?
45. What's the difference between a secured and unsecured education loan?
46. Do I need a co-signer for an education loan?
47. Can I get a U.S. student loan without a U.S.-based cosigner?
48. Are there tuition payment plans so I don't have to pay the full year upfront?

5. F-1 Visa Process (20)

49. What is an F-1 visa, and how is it different from J-1 or M-1?
50. What is the DS-160 form, and how do I fill it out correctly?
51. How do I book a visa interview appointment, and how far in advance?
52. What documents should I bring to my visa interview?
53. What questions do visa officers usually ask?
54. What is Section 214(b), and why do so many students get denied under it?
55. How do I prove "strong ties" to my home country?
56. Will a prior visa denial hurt my chances if I reapply?
57. Can I reapply for an F-1 visa immediately after a denial, or do I need to wait?
58. What should I say if asked why I chose a lesser-known university?
59. Do I need to explain gaps in my education or employment history?
60. How should I explain who is funding my education?
61. What if my sponsor is not my parent — can a relative or family friend sponsor me?
62. How early can I enter the U.S. before my program start date?
63. What happens if my visa is approved but I miss my program start date?
64. Can I bring my spouse or children with me on an F-1 visa?
65. What is the visa stamping fee, and is it different from the SEVIS fee?
66. Do I need to show my visa to CBP officers at the U.S. port of entry, or do they use a different system now?
67. What is a Form I-20, and do I need the original at the airport?
68. Can I switch universities after getting my visa approved for a specific school?

6. Working in the U.S. (On-Campus, OPT, CPT) (8)

- 69. Can international students work while studying in the U.S.?
- 70. How many hours per week can I work on-campus during the semester?
- 71. What is CPT (Curricular Practical Training), and when can I use it?
- 72. What is OPT (Optional Practical Training), and how long does it last?
- 73. What is STEM OPT, and does my major qualify for the extension?
- 74. Can I start a business or freelance while on an F-1 visa?
- 75. Do I need special work authorization for a paid internship?
- 76. What happens to my work authorization if I change jobs after graduation?

7. Pre-Departure Preparation (10)

- 77. What documents should I carry in my hand luggage (not checked baggage)?
- 78. How much money in cash can I legally carry into the U.S.?
- 79. What should I pack that's hard to find in the U.S.?
- 80. Do I need an international driving permit, or can I get a U.S. license?
- 81. Should I open a U.S. bank account before or after I arrive?
- 82. What's the best way to send money from home for ongoing expenses?
- 83. Do I need a domestic SIM card immediately, or can I use an eSIM at first?
- 84. What vaccinations or health records does my university require before arrival?
- 85. Should I buy health insurance before I leave, or does the university provide it?
- 86. How do I find housing before I arrive — on-campus vs. off-campus?

8. Life After Arrival in the U.S. (14)

- 87. What do I do first when I land — check in with the international student office?
- 88. How do I register for classes once I arrive?
- 89. What is my Designated School Official (DSO), and when do I need to talk to them?
- 90. How do I maintain "full-time student status" so I don't violate my visa?
- 91. What happens if I drop below full-time credits for a semester?
- 92. Can I take a semester off (leave of absence) without losing my visa status?
- 93. How do I renew or extend my I-20 if my program takes longer than expected?
- 94. What happens to my visa status if I fail classes or get placed on academic probation?
- 95. Can I transfer to a different U.S. university after I've already started?
- 96. How do I file U.S. taxes as an international student?
- 97. Do I need a Social Security Number (SSN), and how do I apply for one?
- 98. What happens to my visa status if I graduate — how long can I legally stay?
- 99. Can my F-1 visa lead to a path toward a green card later?
- 100. What should I do if my passport or I-20 is lost or stolen while I'm in the U.S.?

Suggested use: Cross-reference against Sofia's system prompt ([app/src/lib/gemini.ts](#)) and the [/resources](#) page — many of these map directly to blog articles or downloadable checklists worth adding if they don't already exist.